Product design / Independent commerce

Utopia Vinyl

Reconnecting my father's collection with returning collectors and first-time buyers.



NT$8,590

confirmed paid order totals

9 orders / 15 LPs

rolling 30-day store snapshot

Sep - Nov 2026

design, build and ongoing iteration

Revenue includes shipping; snapshot captured 4 Nov 2026. Read the results page for scope and attribution limits.

Context

A stockpile of records. A lost connection.

The project began with a practical family problem, not a blank brief for an online store.

Years of collecting had left my father with more vinyl than he could easily connect to buyers. MyAV, the Taiwanese site he used to reach collectors, closed after its owner chose not to keep upgrading it.

Reconnect the people who already know Tim

Give existing collectors a stable place to see current stock and keep the direct relationship with my dad.

Make a first purchase understandable

Help new buyers identify recordings, judge condition and understand ordering, payment and delivery.

Design challenge: build a shop my father can maintain, and a buying journey people can follow without already knowing how he sells records.

MyAV closure and its reason are background supplied by Alexander, not independently verified history.

Contents / Click a chapter

One connected journey, from shelf to customer.

I owned product direction, interface and brand decisions, feedback review and AI-assisted delivery. Tim supplied the records, grading and payment confirmation.

01 **Start with the collection**

An early catalogue and the emerging identity.

02 **Make selling sustainable**

Accessible uploads, photo tools and batch operations.

03 **Connect browsing to an order**

Independent commerce, guest checkout and follow-up.

04 **Help buyers feel confident**

Accounts, individually written FAQs and buying guides.

05 **Find the next customer**

Marketplace presentation, search and useful content.

06 **Measure, then improve**

Paid results, operational goals and next experiments.

Narrative reconstructed from all 267 available turns in the main development chat, supporting conversations, preserved source and selected live captures. Evidence details are on page 24.

September / The first prototype

Start with a place for the collection.

The first preserved version tested a catalogue structure before the store could accept an order.



The Dad's Vinyl shell gave the collection categories, a browsing structure and room for cover images. It was a starting point for a shop, rather than a finished sales experience.

The limit was operational

There were no records yet. Search was only visual; favourites, sorting and the bag were disabled. My dad needed a way to turn physical records into actual listings.

The next decision

Build the seller workflow alongside the customer-facing catalogue, so the inventory could grow without me maintaining every entry.

Historical rebuild from commit 6212ac1, 2 Sep. This is the earliest preserved working shell; no separate original low-fidelity wireframe was found.

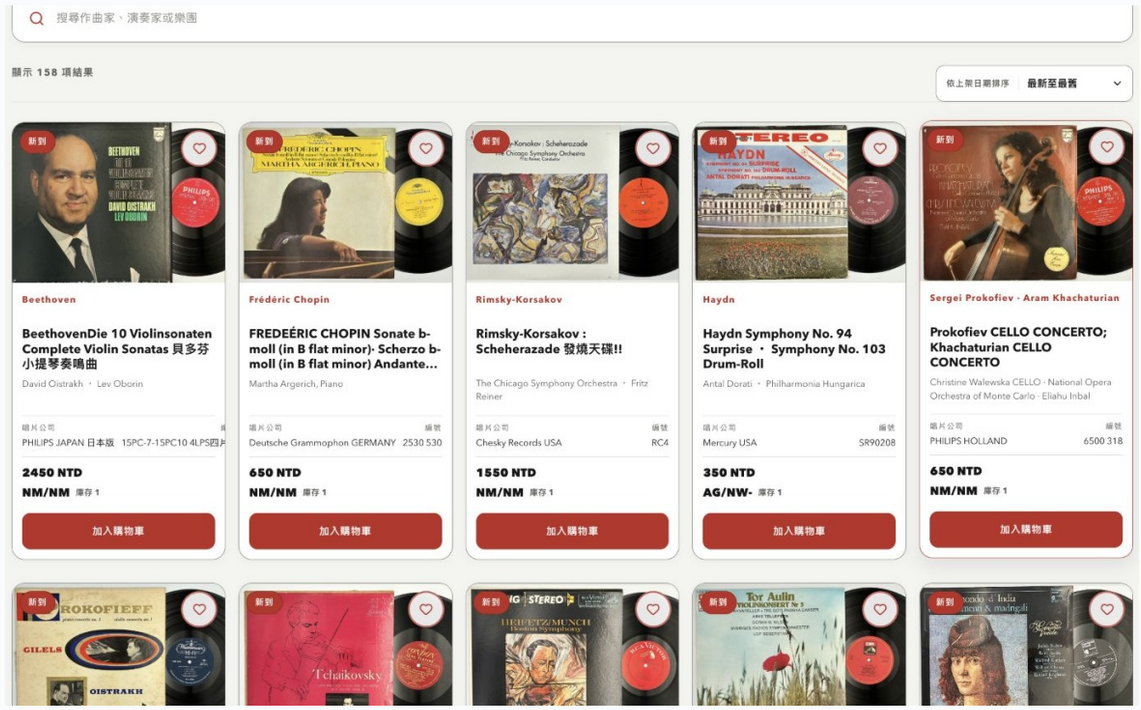
Iteration / Before and after

From empty catalogue to shoppable stock.

Before / 2 Sep prototype



After / 4 Nov catalogue



What changed

Real record photos, performers, catalogue details, grading, prices and cart actions replaced the empty state.

Why it mattered

Recognition over recall: collectors can inspect the facts beside each LP, then act without remembering details from another page.

Historical rebuild versus live catalogue crop; different capture widths. This compares capabilities, not responsive performance or measured conversion uplift.

Iteration / Before and after

The collection became a recognizable shop.

Before / September landing page



After / November homepage



What changed

The Utopia Vinyl identity moved into a turntable-led homepage with explicit shopping entry points. Later pigeon assets were adapted for the site, social profiles and emails.

Why it mattered

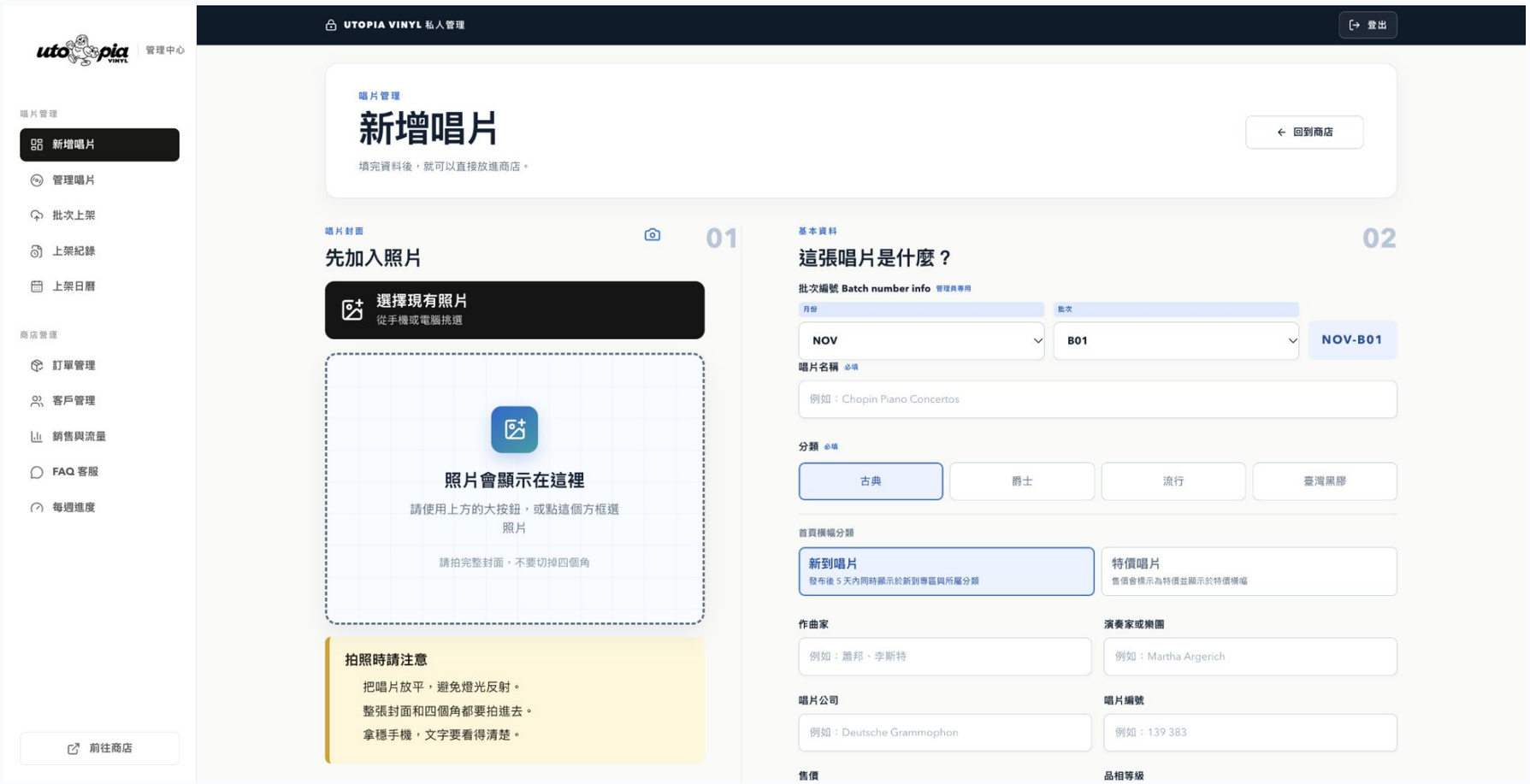
A consistent identity helps returning collectors recognize Tim's shop; clear calls to action give newcomers a place to begin.

September is a historical client-only rebuild. Brand development also included transparent and circular profile variants and a pigeon animation for empty collections and email footers.

Seller / Accessibility as a requirement

Design the uploader for my dad.

His eyesight and comfort with the interface shaped the workflow, not just the visual polish.



Bigger targets, clearer feedback

The upload flow gained larger, higher-contrast controls and a visible photo preview. Technical inventory explanations were removed from the task itself.

Simplify again after trying it

The early instruction-heavy layout was later reduced. The interface kept the useful actions while removing the extra camera option and surrounding instructions.

Development discussion, 20-21 Oct, plus 29 Oct refinements. Current uploader capture, 4 Nov. Accessibility was a design direction, not a formal conformance audit.

Seller / Repetitive work

Automate preparation, keep human review.

Photo handling and record identification evolved through specific feedback and failed attempts.

1

Choose a photo

Start with the sleeve and record visible. The photo confirms which LP is being prepared.

2

Fill and crop

Run metadata recognition on demand; crop outside space while preserving the sleeve and exposed record on the right.

3

Review and publish

Check the title, performer, label, genre, condition and price before making the listing available.

An important repair

The metadata scanner originally failed because its live service was not enabled. We connected Cloudflare recognition; a logged test identified Bill Evans, New Conversations and jazz.

Cost and control shaped the UI

Scanning was made an explicit button action instead of running on every upload. The interface also kept original-photo and lighting controls for manual correction.

History, 29-30 Oct. The recorded version used a daily scan safeguard. No current price or free-tier guarantee is asserted here, and no listing-time reduction has been measured.

Seller / From uploads to a routine

Organize batches, then keep stock accurate.

A large collection needs a repeatable publishing process, not just a good upload screen.

Prepare in batches

Month and batch labels support review, filtering and publication. History and calendar views make past uploads easier to find.

Publish deliberately

Require a valid price before a record goes live. Keep unfinished records as drafts and avoid selecting already-published LPs for publication again.

Keep discovery current

New Arrivals moved through several timing experiments. By the snapshot, records stayed there for five days and remained in their own genres throughout.

One source of stock: adding an LP to a cart does not reserve it. Placing an order makes it unavailable; cancellation is the route for returning it to the catalogue.

This routine connected the seller's organization with the customer's experience: the right stock, in the right category, with a price and availability that could be trusted.

Source milestones: private upload 4 Sep; management 8 Sep; batch publication 17 Oct. Availability rules were tightened again after the late-October reappearance defect.

Commerce / A defining choice

Choose the operating model before adding checkout.

The initial Shopify direction changed once we clarified how my father wanted to sell.

Explored

Shopify integration and inventory synchronization were audited. A safe foundation was built, but it was not an enabled end-to-end Shopify store.

Chosen

One independent Utopia Vinyl system, one custom domain, and manual bank-transfer orders. My dad would keep managing stock, customers and orders in one admin.

Storefront

Browse and build a cart

Order

Submit details; reserve LPs

Tim

Confirm transfer receipt

Fulfilment

Update and ship the order

The interface needed to say “place an order” and explain the separate payment step. That choice shaped the guide, FAQ answers, notifications and order-management timeline.

Architecture discussions, 12-20 Oct. Supabase and payment gateways were discussed; they are not presented as shipped integrations.

Buyer / Testing the path

A buyer should not have to create an account.

Real tester feedback shifted the focus from adding features to removing friction.

On 30 October, I reported that testers were struggling to check out without an account. The route existed, but people could not confidently identify it.

A clearer cart

Guests see checkout and login; signed-in members see checkout. Cart totals and item counts remain visible.

One combined order

Customers can add different LPs, keep browsing, refresh and check out once. Contact and delivery details are entered once.

No dead end after login

The cart is preserved and login returns to checkout. The previously mandatory email checkbox was later made optional.

The local multi-LP prototype was tested before deployment: three different records survived browsing and refresh, then reached one combined guest order.

26 Oct prototype and later deployment; 30 Oct tester report; 1 Nov checkbox change. Reported checks are historical, not a new conversion study.

Buyer / After the order

Make progress visible after checkout.

Order creation is the beginning of fulfilment, not the end of the experience.

01 **Order received**

Number, LP summary and payment instructions

02 **Payment confirmed**

Tim checks funds before updating the order

03 **Shipped**

Shipping update and available tracking details

04 **Delivered**

Complete the visible order journey

Both sides need a signal: customer confirmations and a separate store notification use the Utopia Vinyl email identity. Admin updates and the order page keep the customer informed.

Email sender tested and deployed in October. Later changes removed customer-facing countdowns and automatic release; the current story does not repeat the superseded 48-hour policy.

Buyer / Returning customers

Let accounts add convenience, not a barrier.

The same shop should serve a one-time guest and someone building a collection over time.

For a returning collector

Profile, saved delivery details, wishlist and order history are connected to the shop. Saved contact and shipping information can shorten checkout.

For someone buying once

Guest checkout and order-number lookup remain available. Buying does not require joining the account system.

Navigation was refined through use

Broken links, unwanted homepage redirects on refresh and inconsistent return buttons were corrected. The later account dashboard placed four sections in left-side tabs, reducing page hopping.

A limit kept visible

Tester reports of prefilled credentials were not fully reproduced. We removed a prefilled admin email and investigated autofill, rather than claiming that every reported cause had been resolved.

Account and navigation discussions, 20-30 Oct. Password recovery and verification appeared in early requirements but are not claimed as complete shipped capabilities without evidence.

Buyer / Content before automation

Write the support answers individually.

We created a customer-support helper by building a small, maintained knowledge base around actual buying questions.

01 / Delivery

Available methods and where to confirm the applicable fee.

02 / Payment

Transfer instructions, contacting Tim and receipt confirmation.

03 / Order progress

Guest order lookup and member order history.

04 / Condition

The individual LP's photos, grading and notes.

05 / Contact

Official human-support routes and clear expectations.

06 / The shop's story

A separately maintained answer about the business.

Six enabled entries were observed in the live editor on 4 Nov. These are English summaries of the Traditional Chinese content. Each question, answer and keyword set is maintained separately.

Buyer / Two sides of the support experience

A helper customers can use; answers Tim can own.

The storefront and the private editor share the same approved FAQ knowledge.

Customer / Ask while browsing



Seller / Edit one answer at a time



Find an answer without composing a query

Featured questions support recognition. Keywords connect different phrasing to an authored answer; unknown or ambiguous questions offer help or contact routes.

Test before publishing

The editor supports drafts, a local reply tester, visibility switches and save-to-publish. The shipped helper is rules-based; it does not query personal orders or call a model.

Live helper and editor crops, 4 Nov. A connected generative agent was explored as a future extension, separate from the working curated FAQ.

Iteration / Before and after

Bring buying guidance into the storefront.

Before / Category navigation



After / Visible buying-help links



Where do I learn how buying works?

The earlier header focused on the catalogue.

How to buy. Who to ask. What grading means.

The later header exposes those decisions before checkout.

What changed

Shopping, contact and condition help became explicit destinations above the collection navigation. A separate edition-identification guide was subsequently added.

Why it mattered

First-time buyers may not know grading or transfer payment. Contextual help reduces the need to leave the shop and search for an explanation.

Header crops from September and early 4 Nov captures. Later that day the edition guide added a fourth help link. The original website colours are preserved as screenshot evidence.

Iteration / Reliability and honest presentation

The refinements that made the shop credible.

Testing exposed gaps that a polished homepage alone would not reveal.

Stock reappeared	Ordered LPs resurfaced in New Arrivals after a timeout. Automatic release was removed; the log reports 11 reappearing listings corrected.
Payment update failed	A status label did not match the live database. Payment confirmation and delivery updates were made compatible with the stored states.
Shipping contradicted the banner	The guide and checkout were aligned: free shipping at NT$2,500 merchandise subtotal, otherwise the stated delivery fee.
Trust cues needed evidence	Sample testimonials were removed. Condition copy states visual inspection, and record/sleeve grading is explained instead of implying playback guarantees.

Late-October to 4 Nov history. The website was still evolving; these are documented corrections, not claims that every issue is resolved or that a formal usability study was completed.

Outcome / Recorded sales

The shop is generating confirmed paid orders.

A commercial baseline to build on, with unpaid requests kept separate.

NT$8,590

paid order totals, including shipping

9 orders

15 LPs sold

408 visitors

1,774 page views



4 Nov, approximately 16:40 Toronto / 5 Nov 05:40 Taiwan. Dashboard paid orders are filtered by creation within the preceding 30 days. Another 8 unpaid orders worth NT$5,384 are excluded; that pending total is not date-limited. Visitor IDs may include staff/testing. This is not lifetime revenue, profit or attributable design uplift.

Growth / Make each listing understandable

The marketing journey needed iteration too.

Building the shop did not automatically make individual records discoverable.

The initial problem

Generic Marketplace batch titles made it hard to recognize a specific LP. In one example, the featured Hugo Wolf record was NT$350 while the listing displayed NT$250 from another item.

The correction

Titles were changed to name the first record and mention other stock. The displayed price was aligned with that featured LP, and the description explained the remaining items.

The shop and social channels need to tell the same story: the same record, photograph, price and availability. Facebook posts and Marketplace drafts became routes into the catalogue, rather than a second disconnected inventory.

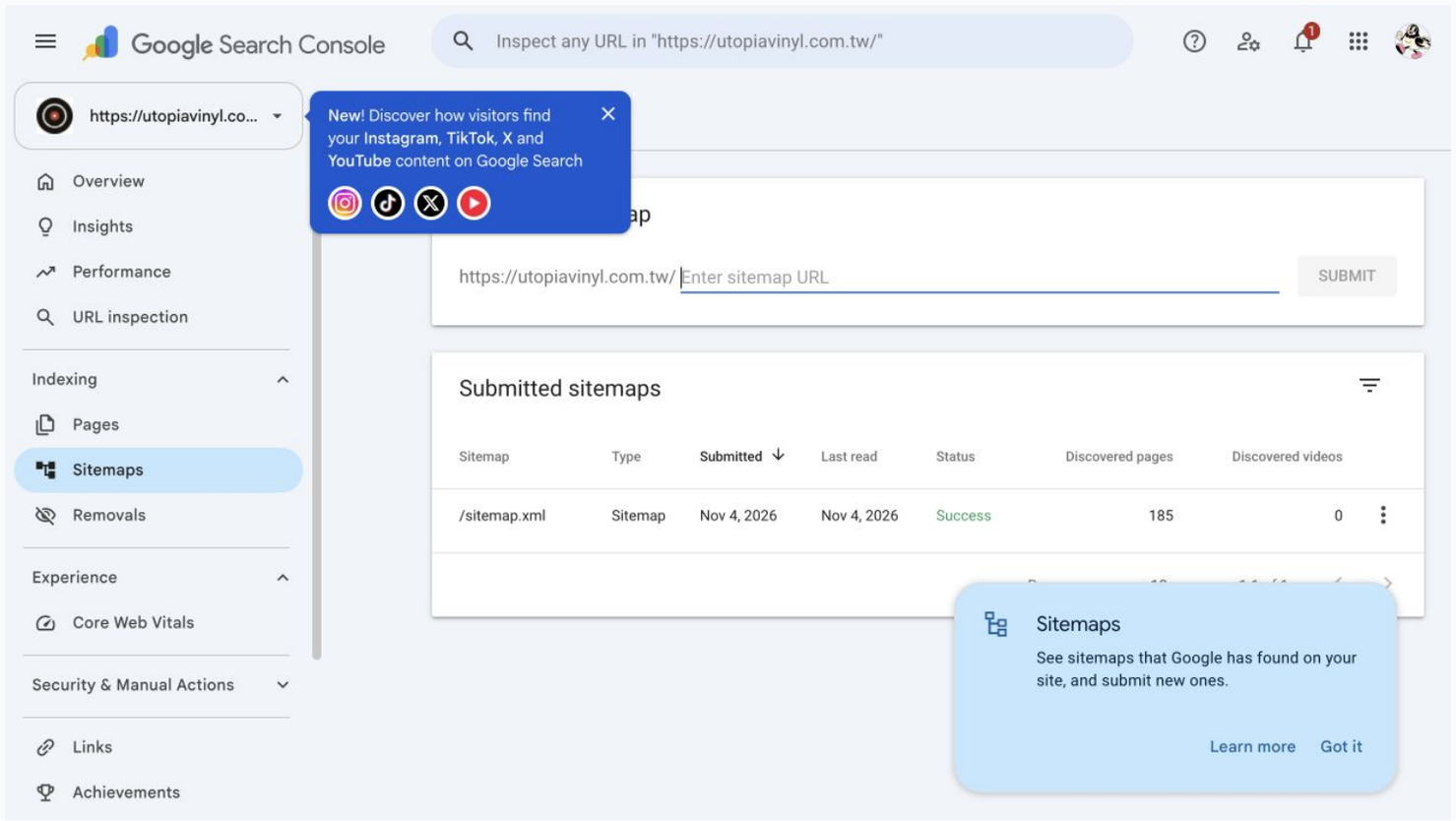
For future community work: participate transparently as Tim from Utopia Vinyl, answer useful questions, and share stock only where the group rules allow.

Marketplace history: 12 active/processing listings had zero clicks at an early check; later batches were saved as unpublished drafts. No channel sales attribution is established.

Growth / Search discovery

Answer the questions before someone buys.

Condition and edition guides extend Tim's knowledge into another way to discover the shop.



What was implemented

Product pages gained searchable details and individual titles. Condition and edition guides linked answers to relevant stock; Search Console ownership was verified and the sitemap processed.

What the result means

Google discovered 185 URLs in the submitted sitemap. Indexing requests were accepted for the guides; discovery and a request do not establish indexing, rankings or search-driven sales.

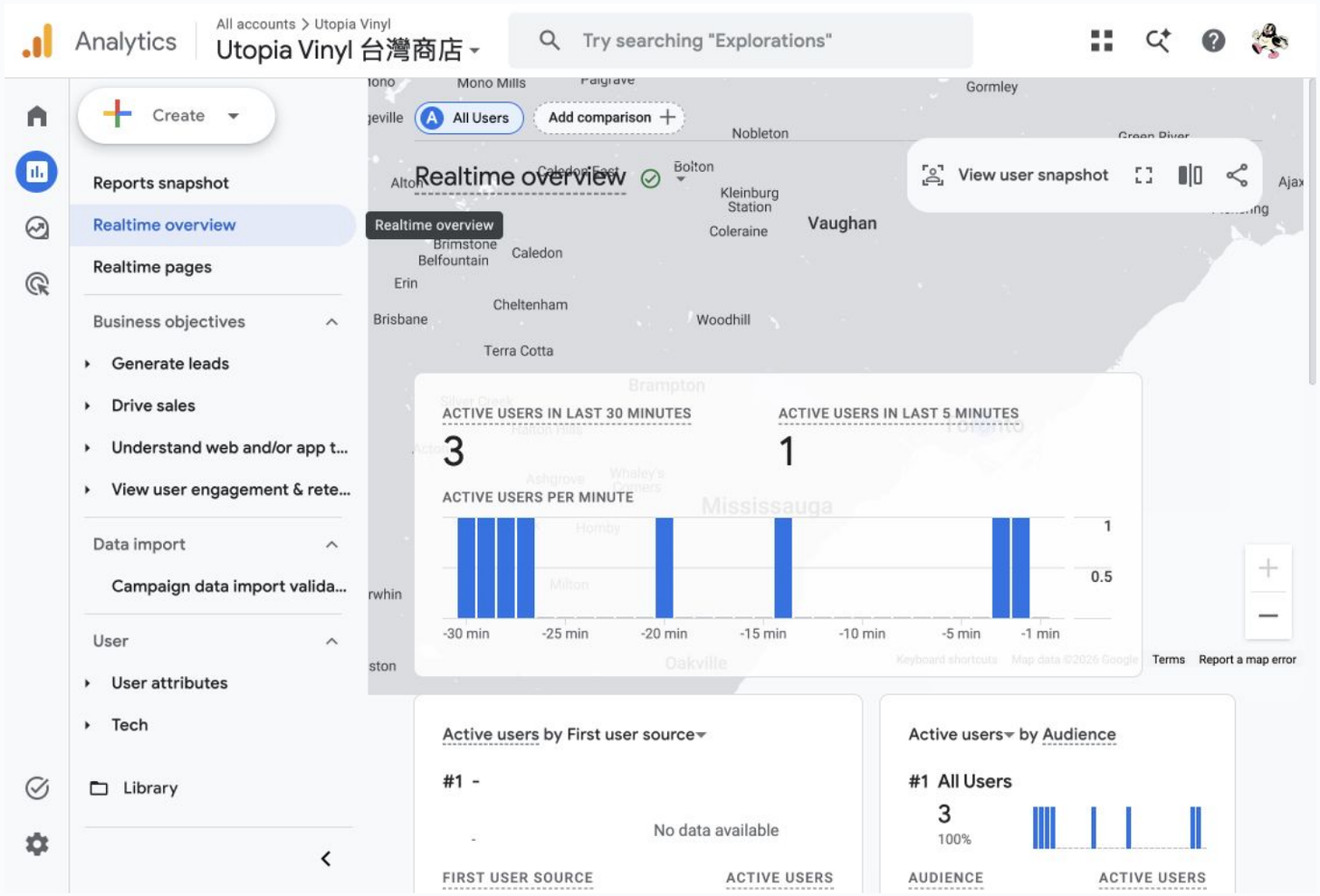
The next learning loop is query -> useful answer -> relevant LP -> paid order. Search data can show which questions deserve better photographs, clearer explanations or another guide.

4 Nov development log and captured Search Console screen. This updates the older PDF, which described verification as pending. Product live testing reported accessible, valid product data.

Learning / Separate the signals

Measure the journey without confusing activity with sales.

The internal dashboard and GA4 answer related but different questions.



Internal store dashboard

Confirms paid orders, order value and stock outcomes. Its 2.2% ratio is paid orders divided by estimated visitors, not a controlled conversion experiment.

Google Analytics

The 4 Nov realtime capture received page views and engagement events. Three active users over 30 minutes may include our own testing; the view is not proof of acquisition growth.

Live presence was added separately: recent active visitors, non-empty carts and LPs in those carts, refreshed every 15 seconds with a five-minute activity window.

Measurement snapshot: 4 Nov. GA4 purchase revenue and channel-level paid-order attribution were not established in this review.

Learning / Keep the shop moving

Turn the stockpile into a weekly operating habit.

Progress reporting was built to support consistency after launch.



Goals evolved with the work

The publishing target moved from 150 to 250 LPs per week. The sales target was clarified as 10 orders, rather than 10 records.

Keep the measures distinct

Historical week tabs and a Monday report support review. Weekly order value includes unpaid orders and shipping; it must not be substituted for confirmed paid revenue.

Recorded weekly dashboard, 4 Nov, and reporting source. The history reports scheduled emails with duplicate protection; this review did not verify receipt of every scheduled delivery.

Next / Continue with evidence

Review discovery, then improve the journey.

Use timed search checkpoints alongside customer feedback and the day-to-day work of running the shop.

After one week

Check whether important pages and both guides are becoming indexed.

After 2-4 weeks

Review Taiwan search queries, impressions and clicks. If traffic is still limited, allow more time before drawing conclusions.

01 / Watch first-time buyers

Observe finding an LP, interpreting grading, guest checkout and explaining payment. Record mistakes and where Tim must help.

02 / Reconnect and acquire deliberately

Invite existing collectors back and test useful contributions in two Taiwan communities. Measure inquiries and paid orders.

03 / Measure the seller workload

Track listing time, corrections after scanning and recurring support questions before choosing the next automation.

04 / Build repeat trust

Keep FAQ answers and guides current, follow up on orders and distinguish first-time from returning buyers.

Search checkpoints are relative to the 4 Nov setup: approximately 11 Nov, then 18 Nov-2 Dec 2026. Discovery or an indexing request does not guarantee indexing or rankings. These are proposed reviews, not scheduled automations.

Reflection / Evidence

The outcome is a selling routine, not just a website.

The strongest decisions connected my father's needs with the buyer's confidence.

I started with a catalogue. The project became a complete routine: prepare the record, publish accurate stock, help someone choose, accept an order, confirm payment and keep the customer informed. AI accelerated implementation; the meaningful work was deciding what to simplify and checking the result.

What this review covered

All 267 available turns in the main Utopia Vinyl chat; relevant customer-browsing and Marketplace conversations; local logo history where the thread reader reached its size limit; September source milestones; current FAQ code; and selected 4 Nov screenshots. A separate posting chat also contained unrelated work, which was excluded.

Store & support

Shopping guide

Condition guide

Edition guide

Design reference

Main development chat

Historical screens are source rebuilds, not launch-day captures; original screenshot colours are unchanged. September commits include 6212ac1, 8e58674, 4b0015a, 953139a and 0c0cb59. FAQ sources: docs/faq-chat.md and lib/faq.ts. Historical checks are reported from the log, not rerun here. No claim of exhaustive access to unavailable/deleted chats, formal usability validation, causal sales lift or guaranteed rankings is made.